



to be accountability, but don't leave him alone when there are problems, because there will always be problems.

I believe that Indians have the talent, there is no deficit of resources and we have the ability to execute big projects—we have seen evidence in both the private and public sector. What we need is to first firm up our objectives and a national commitment to go the whole distance. I repeat, much of this will depend on the leadership. Look at Gujarat and the projects they are executing there. I am not praising the BJP or any particular party. Anybody going to Gujarat can see the difference. It is not because of Narendra Modi alone. It is because of the freedom he has given to people in charge and to bureaucrats. No MLA or MP or anyone can interfere or obstruct a project once it is onstream.

In comparison, in Delhi, a proposal for a tunnelled road from the Games Village to the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium was done in by dissenting groups. It was a brilliant proposal, the Delhi Government, the Games people and chief secretary were all very keen but it didn't happen. A few tree-lovers, the Ministry

DEMOCRACY IS AN ADVANTAGE. PEOPLE ARE LARGELY FOR PROJECTS. WHAT WE NEED IS A SYSTEMIC CHANGE.

cost the organisation Rs 1.45 crore.

We need a definition of our objective. What we need, why we need, where we need it and when we need it. The second step is clarity of ideology. Who will build this and where the money will come from. These days there is a lot of talk about public-private partnership (PPP). To me there is no debate on how infrastructure has to be built. If there is commercial return on a project the private sector will come and build it. If the returns or profits are not there then the government must take it up as a social objective and do it. I don't agree with PPP. If we are to give 40 per cent of the money as viability gap funding, why not do the whole project? And as the debate continues, the confusion continues and projects are being delayed across the country, whether it be metro rail in Kochi and Hyderabad, power projects or expressways. The third step would be identifying the right person for the job. Now this is a combination of merit, integrity and track record. Do you know the cost of any project will come down by 15 per cent the moment people come to know that there is no money-making racket? Fourth, once you find the person, trust him and support him. Yes, there has

of Environment, the Delhi Urban Art Commission and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), everyone raised objections. The issue is not the objections, but that a few people can sabotage any project in India. The tunnel road, an excellent idea, has been abandoned and an elevated road will be built. Any day the tunnel road would have been better. You should have certain checks and balances. But then, there should be somebody who can set it aside and get it done.

I disagree with the notion that democracy leads to delays. I think democracy is an advantage. People everywhere are largely for projects; we can carry them along. What we need is a systemic change. Leadership and commitment make all the difference in getting things done. When we were building the Konkan Railway, the Ministry of Environment was delaying everything. It was S. Bangarappa, who as the chief minister then issued a diktat that all clearances be given to the project. There has to be appreciation that investment in infrastructure delivers a force multiplier for the economy. I believe that if we make up our mind, in 10 years we can change the face of this country. ■